



Figure 1: The default desktop

reconfigure *xserver-xorg*. Then log in by typing: `startx`.

The default desktop looks a bit cluttered with too many icons, but also includes a cool dock allusive of Mac OSX (Figure 1). The 'Engage' dock doesn't require Compiz to work; it uses fake transparency, just like screenlets and gDesklets. Likewise, it won't allow maximised applications to cover it up, which is sort of irritating. Shifting to Compiz will trigger the Avant Window Navigator, a much more feature-rich dock.

The wallpaper is simple and stylish, listing the distro's peers. I really liked the way it listed 'Powered by Debian' and 'Boosted by Flexiboot'. Flexiboot aims to provide a clean boot experience, but I still don't find it as snappy as some of the other new distros that boot in 20 secs or less.

On my system, the distro came up with a decent resolution of 1280 X 1024 pixels. This is impressive considering that the distro doesn't come with the proprietary *ATI/fglrx* drivers.

Coming to the installation steps, the desktop lists many install icons that will surely baffle a new user. Dreamlinux is perhaps the only one of its kind that provides so many options:

1. **OEM Installer:** aimed at an OEM installer, or someone who wants to dedicate the whole PC to Dreamlinux.
2. **Live Dream:** This install option will dump the ISO in a USB drive, making it accessible for booting as a live medium. Please note the changes you made in the live session will not be sustained after you restart the PC.
3. **Persistent Dream:** This option is the same as **Live Dream**. However, it lets you store your settings and changes, so that they're available even after a reboot.
4. **DL Installer:** Now this is the option that lets you install the distro on the hard disk. No frills here. Dreamlinux offers the easiest install wizard I have ever seen -- just one window, with no next tab to click. All options merge perfectly into one window.
5. **'Portable Dream':** This option installs the whole Dreamlinux into the USB, making it a portable operating system. You can thus change things and save files in it, and you won't lose settings after rebooting the desktop. Quite a handy tool for people on the move, and with the plummeting prices of USB drives, it makes sense to have a

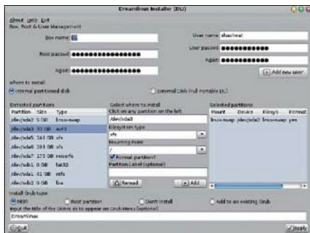


Figure 2: DL Installer



Figure 3: Compiz on the go

USB desktop in your pocket. There isn't a separate installer for this; it is integrated with DL install. Just plug in the external drive, and select the 'External Disk' option under the 'Where to Install' section of the DL Installer.

6. **MkDistro Easy Remaster:** This is a good option that allows you to create your own modified ISO with no hassle. Simply install what you want in *Live* mode and make a different ISO using the Easy Remaster.

There is another icon on the desktop named **Easy Install**, which is not for OS installation. **Easy Install** enables a one-click install for pre-selected applications.

Finally, after fiddling around a bit, I thought of installing the distro and was stunned to see that the installation finished in a mere five minutes.

Riding the dream

Post installation, I rebooted the system and noticed that the boot splash is visible, though it goes into verbose mode now and then. Still, the transition to verbose and boot splash is very smooth. The splash becomes faint before fading into verbose mode or switching to the log-in screen.

After logging in, I was pleasantly startled by the welcome sound, which seemed refreshingly different from the other gloomy sounds that we generally hear as the log in greeting. The desktop remains the same—the Engage Dock and the